

Kumar and Vivek Raghavan, Sarvam has quickly established itself as a frontrunner in building AI tailored for Indian linguistic and socio-economic contexts. The company had already made headlines in August 2024 with the launch of a full-stack, voice-enabled GenAI platform supporting 10 Indian languages—Bengali, Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Odia, Punjabi, Tamil, and Telugu. Backed by Lightspeed Venture Partners and Peak XV Partners, Sarvam’s mission is to build AI that speaks to India.

Industry experts point out that Vivek Raghavan’s experience with the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) has added a layer of credibility to Sarvam.

“This is a crucial step toward building critical national AI infrastructure,” says Raghavan.

Sarvam is focused on advanced reasoning, real-time voice interactions, and fluency in Indian languages—capabilities that set it apart from global models built primarily for English-speaking users. In October 2024, the company also launched Sarvam-1, a 2-billion parameter model optimised specifically for Indian languages.

Still, the road to building a sovereign model has been fraught with challenges, the company says. One of the biggest hurdles has been the lack of high-quality, diverse training data for Indian languages.

Under the sovereign LLM project, Kumar says that the company is developing three model variants.

“Building an AI ecosystem for India has always been core to Sarvam’s mission, the three model variants include Sarvam-Large (for advanced reasoning and generation), Sarvam-Small (for real-time interactive applications), and Sarvam-Edge (for compact on-device tasks),” he explains.

The company is also collaborating with AL4Bharat at IIT Madras, a leading research centre for Indian language AI, also co-founded by Kumar.

While there’s no surety if Sar-

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1 The Government of India has selected the Bengaluru-based company to build the country’s first sovereign LLM—a project expected to be ready within six months

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5 Sarvam is focused on advanced reasoning, real-time voice interactions and fluency in Indian languages—capabilities that set it apart from global models

vam’s models will be open-sourced or not, there are expectations that some components could become more accessible, especially given the government’s backing. As part of the IndiaAI Mission, the Centre is providing Sarvam access to reportedly 4,000 high-end GPUs, out of the total 18,000 commissioned for the initiative.

“Our goal is to build multi-modal, multi-scale foundation models from scratch,” says Raghavan. “When we do, we open the door to a universe of applications. Citizens will engage with AI that feels familiar. Enterprises can unlock intelligence without

compromising data sovereignty,” he adds.

Earlier this year, Microsoft and Sarvam also collaborated to bring its Indic LLM to Azure, a cloud computing platform developed by Microsoft.

“Foundational AI is increasingly powering citizen-centric government services, offering access to information and assistance in citizens’ preferred languages across various digital platforms,” says S. Anjani Kumar, Partner, Deloitte India, adding that the focus should be to invest in creating culturally relevant AI models to cater to Indian languages to address local nuances.

What began as a research lab has now evolved into a full-stack sovereign AI platform, powering governments, enterprises, and non-profits alike at Sarvam. According to the company, its models outperform leading global counterparts on Indian language benchmarks, and are built to be cost-effective, scalable, and rooted in Indian infrastructure.

Sarvam’s early backer, Lightspeed Ventures, says they invested in the company because they saw something special in what they were building and how they were aligned with India’s AI vision.

“Building an AI model for India requires a frugal, ground-up approach—low-cost data, efficient infrastructure, and India-specific training. That’s the challenge Sarvam took on, delivering end-to-end voice models that outperform US rivals in Indian languages and accents at 90% lower cost,” says Hemant Mohapatra, Partner, Lightspeed Venture Partners.

India’s sovereign LLM is not just about technology—it’s a declaration of strategic autonomy. By building and hosting models within its borders and training them on local data, India is staking a claim in the global AI race, with a distinctly indigenous flavour. **BT**

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